Neal T. Gillespie

Austin, TX 78729 • nealtgill@gmail.com • (513) 807-1705 • LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/neal01

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Hiring Committee
Community & Library Services
City of Irvine
One Civic Center Plaza, Irvine, CA 92606

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Page position with Community and Library Services. This is materials-handling work, and materials handling is what I already do every working day. I manage a physical collection, take new items in, sort and shelve them, keep the shelves accurate, and pull what somebody needs. The collection belongs to a fundraising department rather than a public library, and that is the difference I am writing to close.

My current title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the materials are printed fundraising pieces: direct mail letters and their reply devices, printed proposals and reports prepared for major donors, inserts, and newsletters. Every piece we produce ends up in an archive I oversee. I unpack and check in what arrives from the printer, sort and route it, label and process items so they are ready to use, shelve them by campaign and mail code, repair or discard what is damaged, and prepare outgoing deliveries. I am also the main contact for our print vendors, reviewing specifications and keeping several concurrent jobs on schedule.

When that collection grew too large to navigate from memory, I built the system that fixed it. I designed a SQL database for the archive, defined a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, and worked back through several campaign years to catalog it against that standard. On top of it I built a searchable reading room so staff can find a past piece themselves and see where the physical original sits on the shelf.

I have built two more systems on my own time, both public websites. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and built the catalog readers search. StateTrack is a website publishing searchable state campaign finance records for all fifty states. Neither is page work, but both come from the same habit your posting is screening for, which is caring whether an item is where the record says it is.

Before this I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was assembling a small library largely from donated books, and I handled the intake: receiving collections as they arrived, documenting what was in them, processing them onto the shelves, and recording the gift. The one I remember best was a complete set of the *Harvard Classics*. I also walked visitors through that library and helped them locate materials and service areas.

The accuracy your posting emphasises is something I can evidence. As a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law I processed more than five hundred exam records, transcripts and bar documents, where a misfiled record had real consequences, and I staffed the public service window as the first person students talked to.

Two practical notes, both of which your posting lists as requirements. I hold a valid California driver’s license with a clean record, so the delivery runs between facilities are no obstacle, and I am comfortable with the physical side of the work, including lifting and moving up to fifty pounds. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I have family in Southern California who can host me during an interim move, which makes getting out there straightforward.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. Thank you for your consideration, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie